



ALBERTA
PRIMARY AND PREVENTATIVE HEALTH SERVICES

*Office of the Minister
MLA, Red Deer-North*

AR 232629

September 25, 2025

Wayne Sorenson
President, Seniors United Now
37 2016 Sherwood Drive
Sherwood Park AB T8A 3X3

Sent via email: unitenow@telus.net

Dear Wayne Sorenson:

Thank you for your letter regarding health care issues affecting Alberta seniors, including health care staffing, surgery and emergency department wait times, long-term and continuing care funding, and increasing health-related costs.

As you may know, we are refocusing health care to create a more effective, unified system that centres around four priority sectors: acute care, primary care, continuing care, and mental health and addiction.

We also continue to support the attraction, training, and retention of health professionals, particularly in rural and remote communities. [Budget 2025](#) allocates \$644 million for primary care to attach every Albertan with a primary care team and improve access to family doctors and frontline health care professionals. This work is supported by Alberta's [Health Workforce Strategy](#), which addresses specific challenges in rural and remote communities, and expands medical education capacity, including increasing the number of physicians trained in the province.

As well, we are using innovative approaches to expand care so that more Albertans can seek assistance without going to a hospital. Patients can access no-fee virtual care providers, such as [Telus Health](#), for short-term medical issues, or use the [Find a Doctor](#) tool to locate a family doctor or nurse practitioner accepting new patients. As well, Alberta Health Services' [Know Your Options website](#) offers information about clinics and nearby programs and services.

Further, you may be interested to know that Alberta has seen an additional 1,700 doctors register to work in the province over the last 18 months due to a number of targeted initiatives.

Recognizing that wait times for surgery and specialist appointments are a challenge across all Canadian provinces, we are committed to addressing this issue for Albertans. [Budget 2025](#) invests \$377 million for the [Alberta Surgical Initiative](#) (ASI), which is our plan to increase the number of surgeries and ensure Albertans receive their procedures within clinically recommended timelines. Under this initiative, the [Facilitated Access to Specialized Treatment](#) program allows health providers to quickly submit referrals to specialists with the shortest wait

times or to a patient's preferred surgeon. An additional \$265 million will be invested in the ASI Capital Program to expand, renovate, and build more operating rooms to boost surgical capacity. This funding will support over 316,000 surgeries in 2025-26.

Additionally, thank you for your example of the geriatric multidisciplinary emergency room team model at St. Mary's Hospital. While Alberta's emergency departments triage patients based on medical urgency, we recognize that innovative approaches, such as dedicated geriatric emergency room teams, can play a valuable role in improving patient flow and care quality, particularly for seniors with complex needs. In collaboration with Alberta Health Services, we are implementing initiatives that expand staffing capacity, improve transitions to acute and continuing care, and enhance community-based supports. These efforts help reduce unnecessary emergency department visits and hospital admissions, particularly among seniors.

Regarding long-term and continuing care services, our government remains committed to ensuring strong oversight and high-quality care for residents. There have been no funding cuts to standards, licensing or monitoring for long-term care services in Alberta. Oversight of the continuing care sector is managed by the Licensing and Compliance Monitoring Branch under the Ministry of Assisted Living and Social Services. It licenses continuing care accommodations and inspects supportive living accommodations, continuing care homes, and publicly funded home and community care programs to ensure their compliance with provincial standards.

To further strengthen oversight of continuing care, Alberta's government introduced new regulations, updated standards, and improved licensing processes under the *Continuing Care Act*, which came into effect on April 1, 2024. The *Continuing Care Act* establishes a clear and consistent framework for licensing, compliance monitoring, accommodations, and care delivery.

We are also making investments to expand care in communities, enhance workforce capacity, and improve the quality of care within the continuing care sector, with over \$1 billion from 2023-26 to transform the continuing care system and \$634.6 million over five years from the Aging with Dignity Federal Bilateral Agreement.

In addition, there are financial supports available to eligible persons through the [Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped program](#), the [Alberta Seniors Benefit program](#), [Dental and Optical Assistance for Seniors](#), the [Seniors Home Adaptation and Repair Program](#), [Special Needs Assistance for Seniors](#), and the [Coverage for Seniors Program](#).

Thank you again for writing and advocating for the health and well-being of Alberta's seniors.

Sincerely,



Adriana LaGrange
Minister of Primary and Preventative Health Services

cc: Honourable Matt Jones, Minister, Hospital and Surgical Health Services
Honourable Jason Nixon, Minister, Assisted Living and Social Services